



Understanding Anxiety

The difference between normal worry and clinical anxiety

What Is Anxiety?

Everyone feels anxious sometimes — before a job interview, a big test, or a difficult conversation. That kind of anxiety is normal. But when anxiety becomes constant, overwhelming, or out of proportion, it may be an anxiety disorder. Anxiety disorders are the most common mental health conditions (about 1 in 5 adults) and are highly treatable.

Types of Anxiety Disorders

- **Generalized Anxiety (GAD):** Excessive worry about many things — health, work, money — even without specific cause
- **Social Anxiety:** Intense fear of being judged or embarrassed in social situations
- **Panic Disorder:** Sudden, intense fear episodes with racing heart, chest tightness, difficulty breathing
- **Specific Phobias:** Extreme fear of a particular thing or situation (heights, flying, animals)

Common Symptoms

Physical:

- Racing or pounding heart; sweating, trembling
- Muscle tension (neck, shoulders, jaw)
- Upset stomach, nausea, shortness of breath
- Dizziness or lightheadedness

Mental and Emotional:

- Constant "what if" worrying or expecting the worst
- Difficulty concentrating or mind going blank
- Feeling restless, on edge, or keyed up
- Avoiding situations that trigger anxiety

The Anxiety Cycle

1. Trigger	Something happens (or you imagine it happening)
2. Anxious thoughts	"What if something bad happens?" — mind races
3. Physical response	Heart races, muscles tense, breathing speeds up
4. Avoidance	You avoid the situation to feel safer
5. Short-term relief	Feels better briefly, but anxiety grows stronger next time

Breaking the cycle means learning to face anxiety instead of avoiding it — with support and at your own pace.

Treatment Options

- **Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT):** Identify and change thought patterns that fuel anxiety — one of the most effective treatments
- **Exposure therapy:** Gradually and safely face feared situations so they lose their power over time
- **Medication:** Anti-anxiety medications or antidepressants can reduce symptoms while you build coping skills
- **Relaxation techniques:** Deep breathing, progressive muscle relaxation, and mindfulness calm the stress response

5 Things You Can Try Right Now

1. **Grounding (5-4-3-2-1):** Name 5 things you see, 4 you touch, 3 you hear, 2 you smell, 1 you taste.
2. **Slow breathing:** In for 4 counts, hold for 4, out for 6. Repeat 3–5 times.
3. **Schedule "worry time":** 15 minutes a day for worrying. Outside that, write worries down for later.
4. **Move your body:** Walking, stretching, or movement burns off stress hormones.
5. **Talk to someone:** Sharing what you're going through makes anxiety feel less overwhelming.

When to Seek Help

If you or someone you know is in crisis, please reach out:

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline	Call or text 988 (24/7)
Crisis Text Line	Text HOME to 741741
Emergency Services	Call 911
SAMHSA Helpline	1-800-662-4357 (free, 24/7)

You don't have to face this alone. Help is available and recovery is possible.